

Jia Jun Wu

Response #1

Date: 09/26/2023

Name of the reading:

“2.1.4 The Acceptance of Women into the Order” (Source: Translated from Sanskrit “Manual of Discipline for Nuns of the School of the Great Communityites”) in John Strong, *Experience of Buddhism* Chapter 2: pp. 63-67

Passage 2.1.4 tells of the legend of how women were accepted to the Sangha. It offers an explanation and a history to how women were finally accepted into the Sangha and the eight special rules they must follow. While this legend explains how women were accepted into the Order, it also offers many insights into the social climate of the Buddha’s time, as well his thoughts on women and his teachings in relation to the acceptance of the women into the Sangha.

The passage begins with Gautami (stepmother of the Buddha) and hundreds of women approaching the Buddha to ask for the ordination of women into the Order. She says “Blessed one, the appearance of Buddhas in this world is rare; instructions in the True Dharma is difficult to obtain. But now the blessed one has appeared, and the Dharma whose preaching is conducive to tranquility and parinirvana is being expounded by him and is causing the realization of ambrosial nirvana”(2.1.4, line 5-9).

Through this line, Gotami expresses the desire for the teachings of the Buddha because Buddhas and their teachings are scarce, and may even suggest that other spiritual guidance can be impure or misguided and that Buddha’s Dharma is the true one for release from Samsara. In the following line, parinirvana (nirvana after death) is mentioned, which further suggests that the

women are aware of the parinirvana, despite not following the True Dharma. This also confirms the knowledge of the existence of parinirvana, which we can assume to be the doings of the Buddha despite not dying yet. Following the plea, Buddha rejects the ordination of women into the Order and wanders off to Kosala. In an act of determination and perseverance, Gautami and her companions “cut their own hair, acquired their own robes, attached themselves to the Blessed One’s party, and followed after him” (2.1.4, line 25-27). This highlights an important view of women in the context of cultural attitudes of Buddhists towards women. It suggests that Gautami and her band of companions were not permitted into the Sangha, and thus they also did not travel along with the Buddha and his group of monks. At that time, traveling alone was especially dangerous for women and they could be subjected to rape and murder in a time where women were regarded as less than equals. So despite not fully acknowledging the ordination of women to become Nuns, this excerpt here recognizes the absolute determination and capability of these women in pursuit of learning from the Buddha, despite not guaranteeing the ordination and risking their lives to learn from the Dharma of Buddha.

Following this, a continuation of pleading to the Buddha by Gautami and Ananda (of allowing women to be ordained into the Order were continuously rejected until Buddha remarked a long description of what it is like to ordain women into the Order. He likens it as a disease falling upon a ripe field of grain, a red rust falling on a field of sugarcane, and a great storm falling on a field of rice. Now this particular description can be a reflection of what the Buddha believed of women and some might even argue that it is not necessarily his thoughts on it, but rather the monks hundreds of years after his death. However, I argue that Buddha is not comparing calamities to women, but as outside events that will fall upon the Order and society should he ordain women into the Sangha. To me, Buddha is recognizing the cultural attitudes and

the social climate was not friendly to women at the time, and thus the ordination of women as Nuns would certainly create an issue for the Order itself. This is supported by the following sayings by the Buddha, he says in response to Ananda's question of how many assemblies did previous Buddhas have, "Previous Buddhas, Ananda, had four assemblies of disciples, to wit, monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen" (2.1.4, line 100-101). This showcases an important idea here, and it is that women have been previously ordained as Nuns into the Sangha. This shows that the act has been done and sets a precedent. However, it also suggests that the Buddha believes the time to ordain women into the Order is not right, and that the underlying social climate towards women at that specific time discourages the recognition of women in monastic practice.

Furthermore, the Buddha also says "Yes, Ananda, a woman who is earnest and zealous and who dwells in seclusion can realize these four fruits of the monastic life" (2.1.4, line 107-108). This is particularly important as Buddha fully recognizes that women are equal in the pursuit of Nirvana. It shows that women are just as equally capable as men to realize the four fruits of enlightenment, and therefore achieve Nirvana. This highlights an extremely liberal view of women relative to the cultural attitudes towards women at the time, and acknowledgement that women can also achieve the ultimate goal in Buddhist doctrine is of huge significance. However, the Buddha still shows reluctance in ordaining women as Nuns until he reflected on how it would affect Ananda. He recognizes that Ananda would keep asking him to ordain women into the Order and cause distress in the mind, and would rather the Dharma last 500 years shorter than for that to happen. This shows insight into Buddha himself. He is able to understand that his disciples will teach the Dharma onto the following generations and a mentally distressed disciple will obfuscate the teachings which will be harmful.

In the end, the Buddha relented and allowed for women to be ordained into the Order with the condition of following the eight rules. These rules were quite unequal and reflected cultural attitudes at the time towards women. Rules ranged from a nun must always salute a monk despite having seniority to nuns not receiving basic commodities before monks. However, these rules contrast against the acknowledgement of women's capabilities to attain Nirvana by Buddha himself, which is regarded as the supreme spiritual goal of Buddhist doctrine. This shows two very different beliefs in the capabilities of women. Are they truly equal or not?

In the end, we would likely never know what role did Buddha intended for women to have, whether it is as lay people or as Nuns. And I believe that even my explanation is not fully complete. There can be a variety of reasons as to why Buddha rejected women from the Sangha in the first place, and while the perception of society at the time can contribute to the reason for rejection, there can be other factors such as geopolitical conflicts, political climates and perhaps even the temptation of women. However, from this text, we can gather that the contradiction is what likely reflects the cultural attitude of Buddhists about gender, that women are capable of attaining Nirvana but also must be constrained by the rules of the Vinaya as well as the eight cardinal rules in order to do so. In the end, this reading did ultimately challenge my views on women in Buddhism. I originally thought that women were viewed as non-important in Buddhism but the Buddha acknowledging the equal opportunity to attain Nirvana by both women and men is enlightening. It showed I had a rather narrow view of Buddhism and that generally the cultural attitudes of Buddhist towards gender were complex and ever-changing as shown in the passage of this text.